Strategic Management Kind Case Study

Contents

1. Abstract

This strategic analysis of Kind identifies pressing challenges that threaten its brand integrity and market competitiveness. Despite being a market leader, there is a critical misalignment between Kind's health centric brand promise and its product offerings. The inclusion of processed ingredients in products such as frozen treat bars contradicts the company's commitment to natural and healthy snacks. This discrepancy risks alienating Kind's core consumer base. Moreover, Kind faces growing competition from both incumbent competitors, private label brands and new entrants to the market.

This report recommends that to reinforce its market position, Kind should pursue a B Corp certification to realign its product development with its core values. This includes reformulating existing products and enhancing transparency about ingredient sourcing and manufacturing processes. Such steps will help regain consumer trust and compete with competitors like Clif, who are more open about their processes. Kind must capitalise on its resources to innovate within health and nutrition focused segments of the snack bar market. By developing products that cater to specific dietary preferences, such as organic or keto options, Kind can align more closely with consumer health trends and secure a competitive advantage in a saturated market.

In conclusion, while Kind has established a significant foothold in the snack bar industry, strategic realignments in product offerings and operational transparency are crucial to sustain and enhance its market position amidst evolving consumer expectations and intense competition.

2. Introduction

This report has been conducted by a third party strategic consultant, on behalf of Kind LLC (Kind) to analyse their strategic direction, associated risks and problems in North America, providing subsequent recommendations for the next five years.

Founded in 2004, Kind is a snack bar company committed to offering products made with natural ingredients, including whole nuts, fruits and grains (Kind, n.d. -c). The name "Kind" and it's vibrant branding mirrors the company's dedication to delivering snacks that are not only delicious and convenient but also sustainable and socially impactful (Kind, n.d.- a). Daniel Lubetzky, the founder, supposedly epitomises the ethos of a not just for profit business, leveraging his entrepreneurial spirit to drive positive social change (Lubetzky, 2015). Kind bars are now found in around 20% of American households (Doering, 2023).

2.1. Timeline

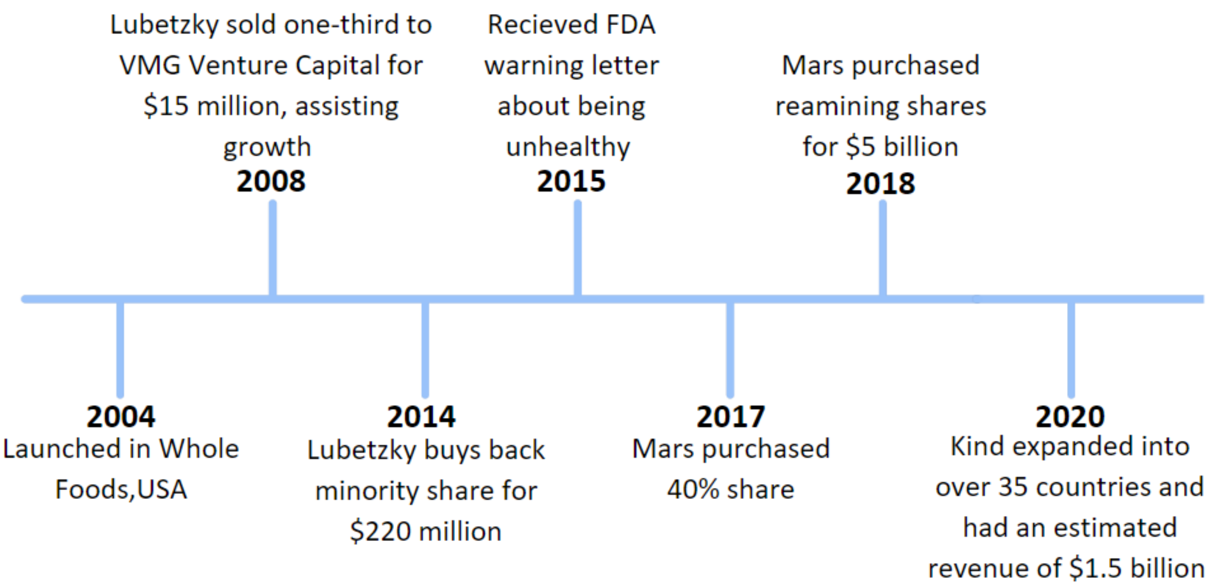

Figure 1: Key Dates in Kind's History (Lamare, 2021; Mars, 2020; Sorvino, 2023)

2.2. Business Model

Kind's business model caters to young and middle aged adults and despite not being exclusive to genders, their target market leans towards females who are statistically more likely to snack throughout the day (Feraco et al., 2024). Their consumers are health conscious, requiring convenient snack options while on the go, without having to compromise on their wellbeing (YouGov, 2024). Moreover, their consumers are ethically aware of where ingredients come from and how they were produced, requiring a level of transparency from the producer (Zegler, 2023). Kind centers their business model around this ideal customer profile.

2.3. Core Competencies Overview

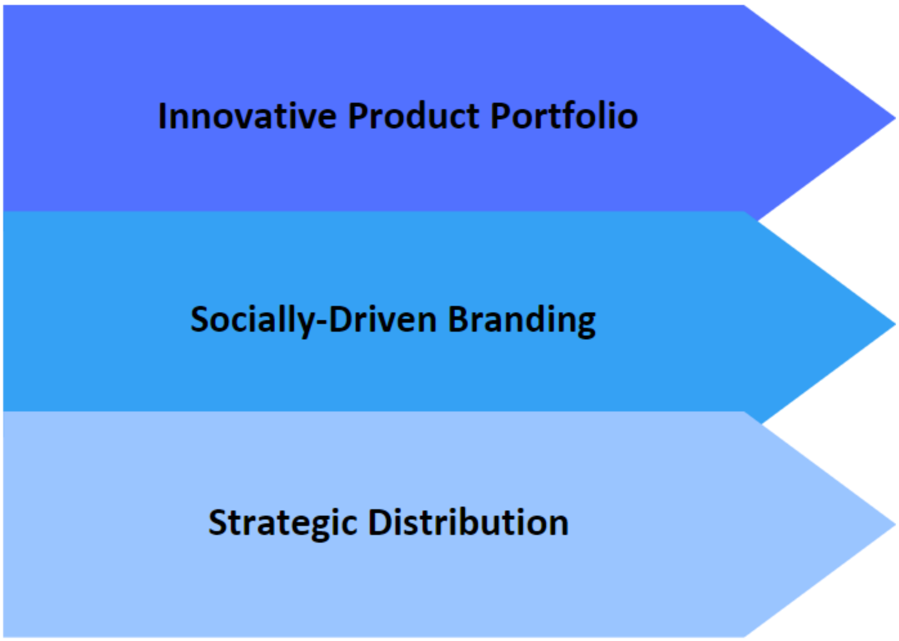

Figure 2: (Lamare, 2021)

2.4. Revenue Model

Kind generates revenue through a range of channels depicted in figure 2:

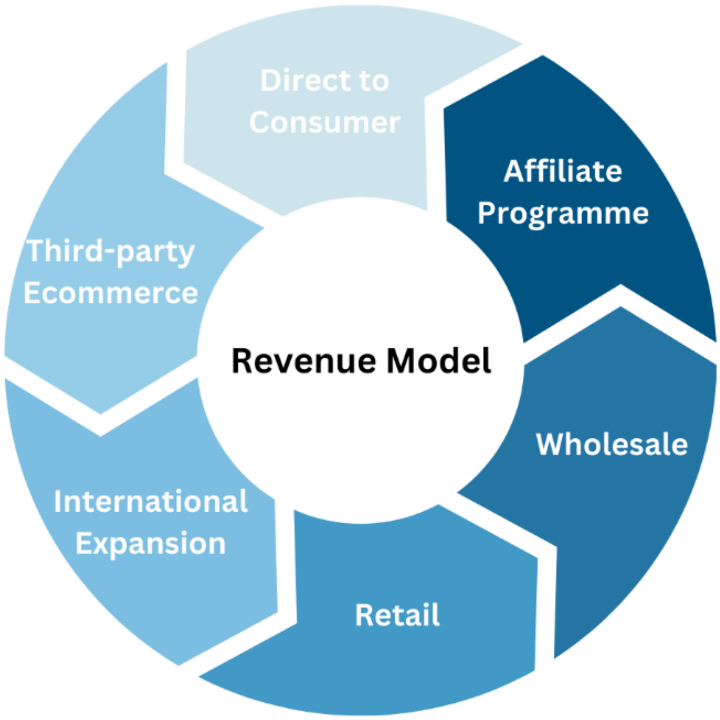

Figure 3: (Kind, n.d. d).

Kind's website provides a platform to sell to their ideal customers with targeted copywriting, tailored subscription boxes that drive loyalty and an AI function that recommends products to consumers; unlike other third party websites where not all SKU's will be present nor will the product placement be optimal (Jones, 2022). This enables Kind to collect unique data about the combination of products purchased together and who by (Jones, 2022). Moreover, Kind leverage third-party websites like Amazon, where they generated the highest sales out of any food category during the November Black Friday event (Kind, 2019). Kind have also utilised Mars' logistics to expand into over 35 countries (Mars, 2020). Furthermore, Kind have partnerships with large retail companies such as Walmart, Sprouts, Kroger and Costco (Mordor Intelligence, .n.d.). Kind's wholesale programme also enables them to increase their sales at a higher volume to businesses throughout the USA (Kind, n.d.- f). Finally, their affiliate programme enables individuals with a social status to drive traffic to Kind's website, receiving a commission for each order (Kind, n.d- g).

Through this model they sell a range of products highlighted in figure 4:

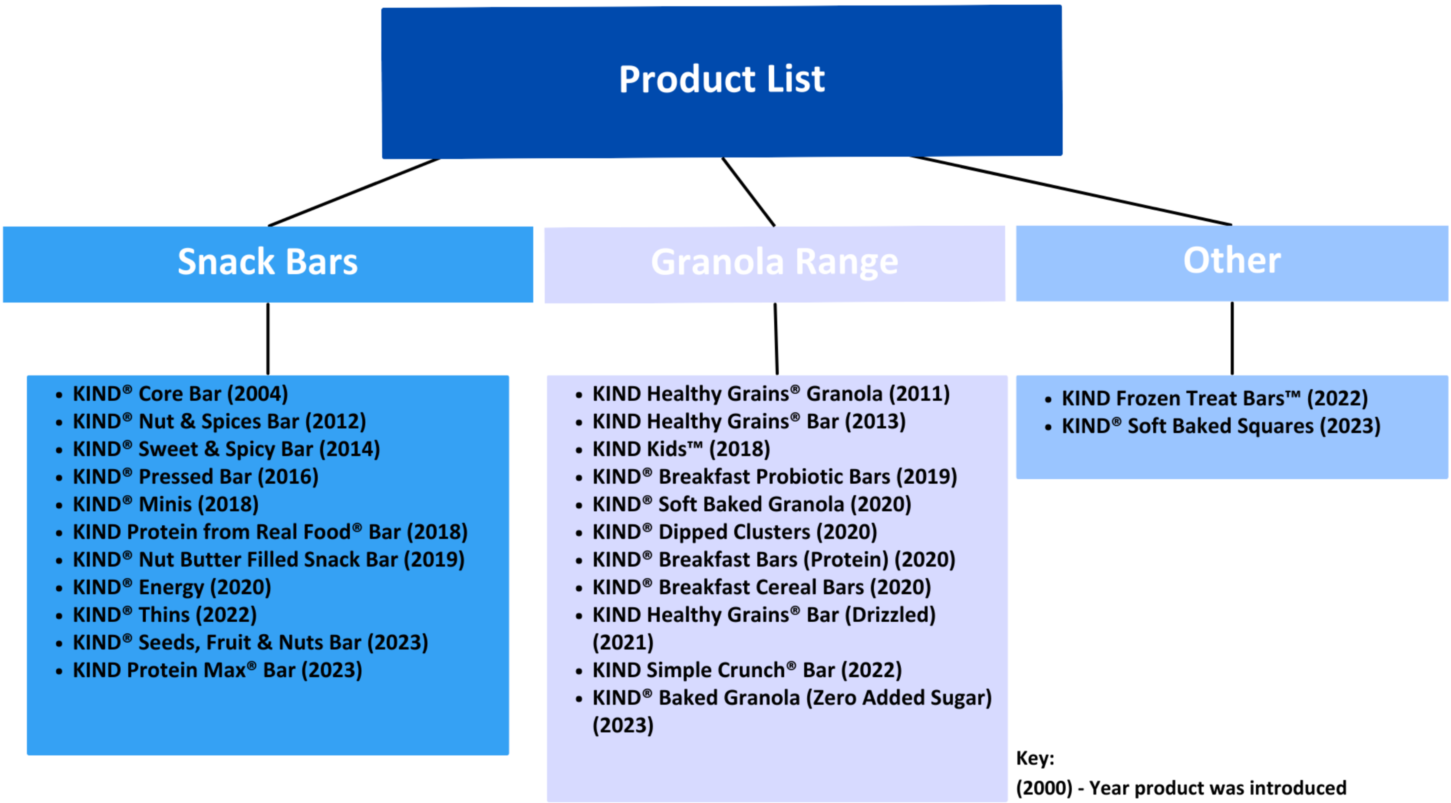

Figure 4: Kind Bars Product Range (Kind, n.d.-d)

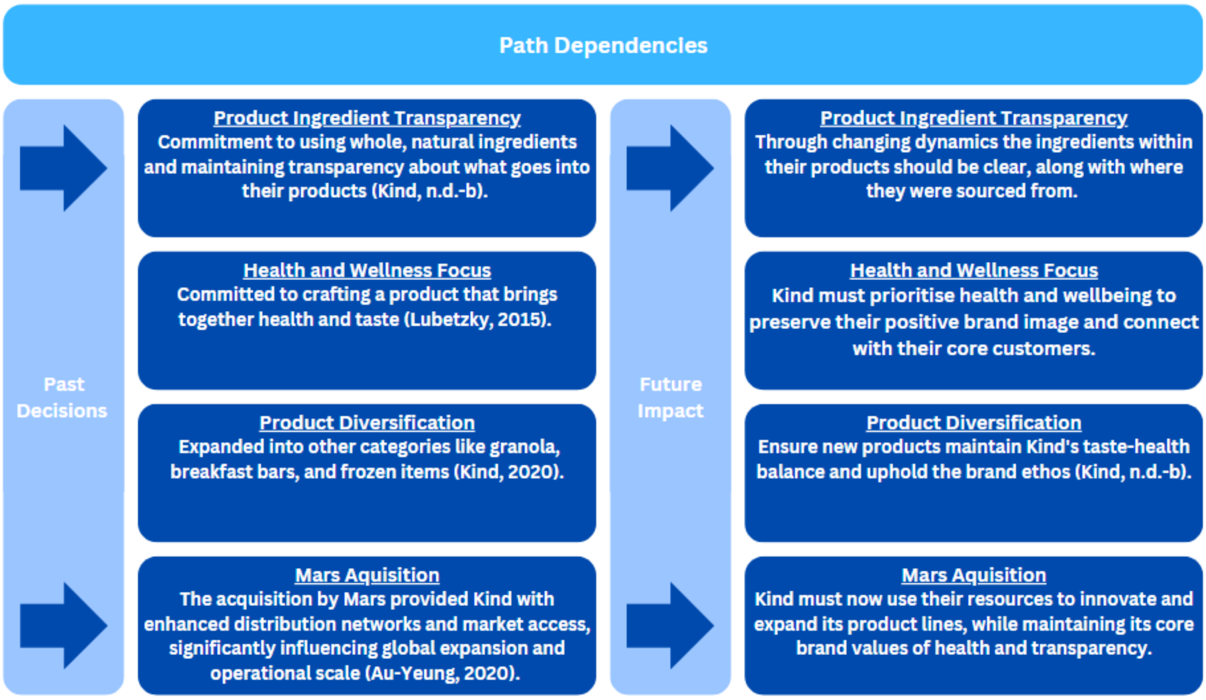

Figure 5: Analysis of Kind's path dependencies

To win in the long run companies must have a commitment to excellence and avoid false promises (Lubetzky, 2015). Brands reflect their customer's unique values and style, thus maintaining this image is of importance (Steiger, 2023). Kind bars are already contradicting their commitment to providing natural and healthy ingredients with their new frozen treat bars, containing processed chocolate, added sugar and syrups (Kind, n.d.-i).

2.5. Competitor Analysis

The North American snack bar market is highly competitive with the top five companies only occupying 38.84% of the market (Mordor Intelligence, n.d.).

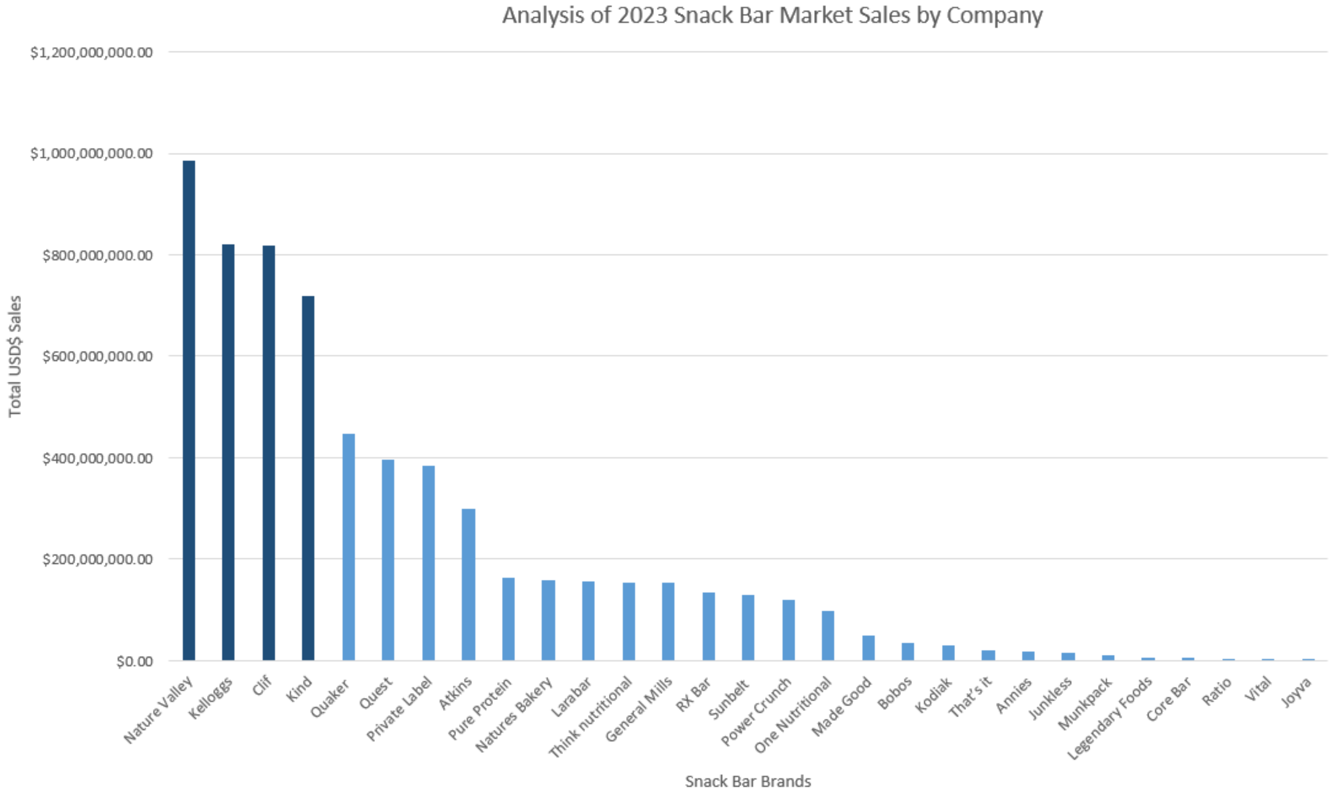

Figure 6: Industry Leaders Total Sales in North America, 2023 (SOI, 2023)

Nature Valley, Kellogg's, Clif, and Kind are the leading revenue generators in the snack bar market. However, Clif, acquired by Mondelez (with a £36 billion net revenue in 2023, Mondelez, 2024), emerges as Kind's main competitor, offering similar healthy snack bar alternatives (Parker, 2023).

3. Situation Analysis

3.1. Industry Overview

According to IFIC (2023), 72% of Americans snack at least once daily in addition to their main meals, with 62% citing healthiness as a key factor influencing their purchasing decisions in supermarkets.

Moreover, 51% of US consumers aged 18-54 use snack bars as meal replacements (Conway, 2023). Sales data reveals a 9.2% increase between 2022 to 2023 in the snack bars industry, totalling $7.58 billion (SOI, 2023). Specifically, granola bars rose by 11.1% to $1.638 billion, 'nutritional/intrinsic' health value bars grew 5.2% to $3.53 billion, and breakfast bars jumped 10.8% to $2.145 billion (SOI, 2023). The 'All Other Snack/Granola Bars' category saw a notable 50.7% growth, primarily driven by private label brands (SOI, 2023).

Despite the financial pressures, where 57% of US adults feel the rising cost of living makes sustainability less crucial, health remains a priority, especially for Generation X who favour 'better-for-you' options (Zegler, 2023). Zegler (2023) also highlights that over 95% of all age groups in the US are attempting to maintain or enhance their health, with notable efforts from older generations. Evidently, it's clear that across all demographics in North America, there's a growing trend towards choosing snack options that are healthier and less processed.

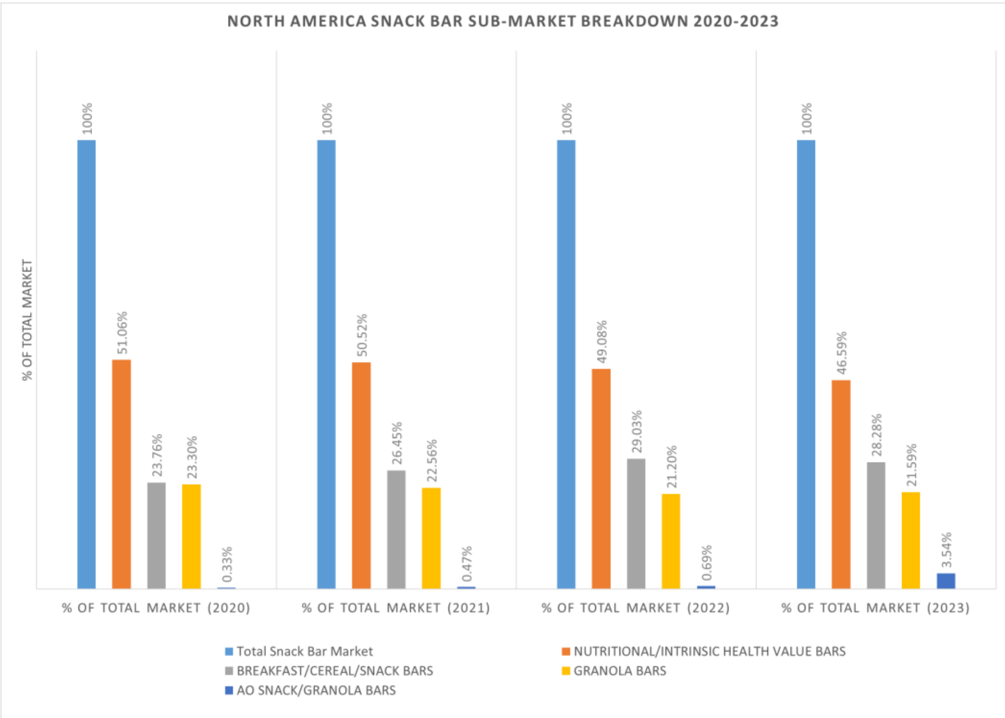

Figure 7: (Adapted from IRI, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023)

Figure 7 shows that since 2020, the health value bar market has lost 4.47% market share, while the 'all other' snack bar category has gained 3.21%. This highlights the growing influence of new entrants (refer to figure 6) and their significant impact on market dynamics, despite overall market growth.

3.2. Internal Analysis

3.2.1. VRIO

VRIO Analysis					
Resource/ Capability	Valuable	Rare	Inimitable	Organised	Competitive Consequences
Supply Chain	Y- Mars' supply chain will decrease costs and increase revenue (Mars, 2020).	Y- Hard to replicate Mars' supply chain and Almond farms (Kind, 2022).	Y- Hard to source almonds at volume (Athwal, 2021).	Y/N- Mars' proven track record ensures stability (Mars, 2020). However, Kind's reliance on Almonds is threatened by global warming and limited supplier optionality (Athwal, 2021).	**Sustained Competitive advantage**
Employees	Y- leadership team previously working at Mars have valuable experience (Mars, 2020).	Y- takes years for leaders to gain experience and manage a company of Kind's size.	N- over time employees will upskill to a level similar to Kind, while employees at Kind could be hired by competition.	Y- Kind has an organised work culture (Glassdoor, 2024).	**Temporary Competitive Advantage**
Innovative Product Range	Y- expanding to reach new market segments and audiences (Kind, 2020).	Y- Takes a long time and a lot of capital to expand into so many sub markets.	N-Although it is hard to source almonds, there are similar substitutes within the snack bar market.	Y- Kind has a clear Innovative plan, aided by Mars' historic record in expanding product ranges to meet customer needs (Kind, 2020).	**Temporary Competitive Advantage**
Diversified Revenue Streams	Y- range of revenue drivers (refer to Figure 3)	Y- hard for most companies to mirror all of their revenue streams	Y- hard to reach this level due to capital and time constraints.	Y- Kind have a clear strategy to maintain their revenue streams.	**Sustained Competitive Advantage**
Financial Resources	Y- They have a increased amount of capital from Mars, helping to assist global growth (Sorvino, 2023).	Y- Mars' revenue of $50bn is rare and few companies have access to this level of capital (Hand, 2024).	Y- Mars' growth provides Kind with more resources, making it harder for others to replicate without huge sums of capital.	Y- Mars' resources and Kind's financial planning provides a clear roadmap for growth.	**Sustained Competitive Advantage**
Online Presence	Y- through Kind's social media, news outlets and third-party platforms.	Y- takes years to build presence in the media that Kind have.	N- although it takes time an online presence similar to Kind can be replicated.	Y- their social media and overall marketing is simple and consistent (Deyo, 2023).	**Temporary Competitive Advantage**
Intellectual Property	Y- name and logo is synonymous with their mission.	Y- requires a proven track record.	Y- their intellectual properties cannot be replicated due to trademarks and other registered IP's (Kind, n.d.-h).	Y- they have resources to defend their IP's, which are extremely clear (Kind, n.d.-h).	**Sustained Competitive Advantage**

Figure 8: VRIO Analysis of Kind

Figure 8 revealed essential resources for maintaining a competitive edge in the snacking industry. This is crucial given the proliferation of independent brands (SOI, 2023). Despite this, with a wealth of incumbent resources comes a certain level of rigidity (Kotter, 2012), hindering Kind's ability to pivot swiftly compared to new entrants. Figure 6 also reveals that Kind isn't the sole snack bar company with access to these resources. However, the abundance of resources offered by Mars certainly still elicits a competitive advantage within the broader market.

3.2.2. Strategic Factor Analysis

This report conducted a strategic factors analysis, enhancing the identification of Kind's strategic positioning in the snack bar market.

Strategic Factor Analysis Summary									
KIND									
Reference	Key Strategic Factors	SWOT	Weight	Rating	Weighted Score	Priority/Duration			Comments
						Critical	Inter	Long	
S2	Ecommerce channels	S	0.15	4	0.6			X	Key for customer acquisition
S3	Strategic partnerships	S	0.10	4	0.4		X		Acess to a large resource base
W2	'Healthy' Ingredient claims	W	0.15	3	0.45		X		Potenital to damage brand image
W3	Supply Chain Transparency	W	0.15	4	0.6	x			Extremely weak
O1	Health and Wellness Trend	O	0.10	5	0.5		X		Lots more sub-markets to explore
O2	Brand Community	O	0.10	5	0.5		X		Increase connection with audience
O5	Private Label Brands	T	0.15	2	0.3	X			Cost of living increasing this threat
T3	FDA Regulations	T	0.10	3	0.3		X		Constant issue, needs monitoring
Total			1.00	30	3.65				

Figure 9

3.2.2.1. Internal Strategic Factor Analysis

Internal Factor Analysis Summary					
KIND					
Reference	Key Strategic Factors	Weight	Rating	Weighted Score	Comments
	Strengths				
S1	Marketing Strategy	0.10	5	0.50	Omnichannel approach targets consumers with social media and distinctive branding (Dilworth, 2022). Marketing emphasises the bars' real ingredients and health benefits for users and the community (Dejo, 2023).
S2	Ecommerce Channel	0.15	4	0.60	Ecommerce boosts revenue beyond traditional retail. Their subscription model lowers customer acquisition costs and enhances customer lifetime value (Jones, 2022).
S3	Strategic Partnerships	0.10	4	0.40	Acquiring Nature's Bakery and being acquired themselves provides Kind with the resources to expand their output and product range (Evans, 2022).
S4	Innovitive Product Range	0.05	3	0.15	Expanding their product range allows Kind to meet evolving consumer demands and attract a broader demographic.
S5	Clean Label	0.10	3	0.30	Customers increasingly favour less processed snacks with clearly labelled ingredients, yet only 32% of US shoppers prioritise all natural ingredients in their food choices (Zegler, 2023).
	Weaknesses				
W1	Reliance on Almonds	0.10	3	0.30	Relying on a single high fat resource could complicate pivoting if consumer preferences change, given existing concerns about high fat foods (IBIS, 2023).
W2	'Healthy' Ingredient Claims	0.15	3	0.45	Despite Kind's healthy image and 'natural' ingredients, their bars are high in fat and contain palm oil, linked to heart disease and cancer (Robb-Nicholson, 2021). Additionally, artificial ingredients and preservatives may disrupt our biome, causing inflammation, weight gain, and addiction (Strawbridge, 2020).
W3	Supply Chain Transparency	0.15	4	0.60	Despite ingredient transparency, Kind is less open about their full supply chain. They adhere to the Californian Transparency Act, avoiding slavery and trafficking in their direct supply (Kind, n.d.-g). However, they don't reveal the sources of ingredients like cocoa, concerning given the high child labour rates in Ghana's cocoa farms, where an estimated 48% of children work (Sadhu et al., 2020).
W4	Restricted Product Range	0.05	2	0.10	Health and wellness focus limits their ability to maintain their public perception of being healthy, while venturing into more snack supermarkets.
W5	Price Point	0.05	3	0.15	Kind's higher price point is concerning with the rising cost of living crisis (Kind, n.d.-d), where 48% of consumers are consciously choosing cheaper substitutes (Zegler, 2023).
Total		**1.00**	**34**	**3.55**	

Figure 10

3.3. External Analysis

3.3.1. External Factor Analysis

External Factor Analysis Summary					
KIND					
Reference	Key Strategic Factors	Weight	Rating	Weighted Score	Comments
	Opportunities				
O1	Health and Wellness Trend	0.1	5	0.5	Weight management and longevity continue to be key trends among all age groups (IFIC, 2023). Future products should prioritise nutritional value to meet these preferences.
O2	TikTok Shop	0.05	3	0.15	TikTok's new ecommerce feature will boost engagement with Gen Z and millennials and increase revenue through creator partnerships (Escandon, 2023).
O3	Certifications	0.05	4	0.2	Achieving B Corp certification will enhance Kind's trustworthiness and showcase its commitment to purpose driven values (Carroll, 2023).
O4	Brand Community	0.1	5	0.5	Creating a run club boosts community spirit, offers sampling and sponsorship opportunities, and aligns with their brand image (Barkho, 2024).
O5	Organic Snack Range	0.05	2	0.1	The organic market is expected to grow at a 12% compound annual growth rate from 2022 to 2029, identifying a promising sub-market that complements their focus on nutrition (Green, 2023).
	Threats				
T1	Private Label Brands	0.15	2	0.3	Private label brands saw a 102.5% increase in growth between 2021 to 2022, brining in over $13 million in sales (IRI, 2022).
T2	Economic Instability	0.05	3	0.15	Projected economic slowdown and decreased consumer spending are likely to affect Kind's revenue (Chambless, 2023). Despite expectations of slowing inflation, March saw unexpectedly high rates, with food prices increasing by 2.25% from the previous year (Duggan & Adams, 2024).
T3	Climate Change	0.05	2	0.1	Climate change has increased insect damage to California's almond crops, which account for over 80% of the global supply (Kan-Rice, 2023; Athwal, 2021). Additionally, droughts in West Africa have cut cocoa production by 500,000 tons in 2024, driving up prices (Shahbandeh, 2024).
T4	FDA Regulations	0.1	3	0.3	Further speculation over the FDA tightening restrictions on what snack bars can be labelled as healthy (Boradbent, 2023).
T5	Changing Consumer Preference	0.05	3	0.3	Rising health trends show variable consumer responses to different food types, highlighting the need for diverse snack bar options and prompting significant R&D and innovation (Strauss, Short, & Lotfian, 2023). This also creates opportunities for private labels to enter the market (IRI, 2022).
Total		1	32	2.6	

Figure 11

3.3.2. PESTLE Analysis

Factor	Explanation	Term			Impact
		Short Term <1 year	Medium Term 1-3 Years	Long Term >3 Years	
POLITICAL					
Trade Policy	Trade policy shifts can impact the cost and supply of KIND bars' global ingredients.		x		
Agriculture Subsidy	The $30 billion agricultural subsidies lowers the cost of ingredients such as almonds; if reduced, this would raise raw material expenses (Edwards, 2023).			x	
ECONOMIC					
Consumer spending	Inflation causing consumers to choose cheaper substitutes (Zegler, 2023).	x			
Ingredients Cost	Reduced yield in 2024 could increase prices (Shahbandeh, 2024a).		x		
Exchange Rate Fluctuations	Rising strength of the dollar makes importing raw materials cheaper for Kind.	x			
SOCIAL					
Social Media	Increased traffic to their DTC ecommerce platform		x		
Demographic Changes	An aging demographic, actively pursuing health, will boost spending on Kind's products (Zegler, 2023).			X	
Developing Consumer Preference	Keto, paleo, and organic diet trends require Kind to adjust their product line.		X		
TECHNOLOGY					
Advancement in Ecommerce	North American Ecommerce revenue is projected to grow at an annual rate of 8.91% (£2,200bn market volume by 2029) (Statista, 2024a).			X	
Artificial Intelligence	Empower DTC brands to engage their target audience, utilise personalised marketing strategies, and efficiently generate product copy (Forbes, 2023).	x			
Supply Chain Innovations	Advanced in food technology could help Kind maintain their healthy brand image and still diversify their product range.			X	
LEGAL					
Tightened FDA Regulations	FDA changing what can be classified as 'Healthy'.		x		
Supply Chain Laws	Increased regulations at the root of Kind's cocoa source.			x	
Intellectual Property	Continued protection of trademarks and patents.			x	
EVNIRONMENTAL					
Climate Change	Supply of almonds, honey and fruits could decline.		X		
Increased Environmental Concern	A genuine concern that consumers will demand more transparency on (Moriarty, 2024).		x		

Figure 12

3.4. Competitive Environment

3.4.1. Porter's Six Forces

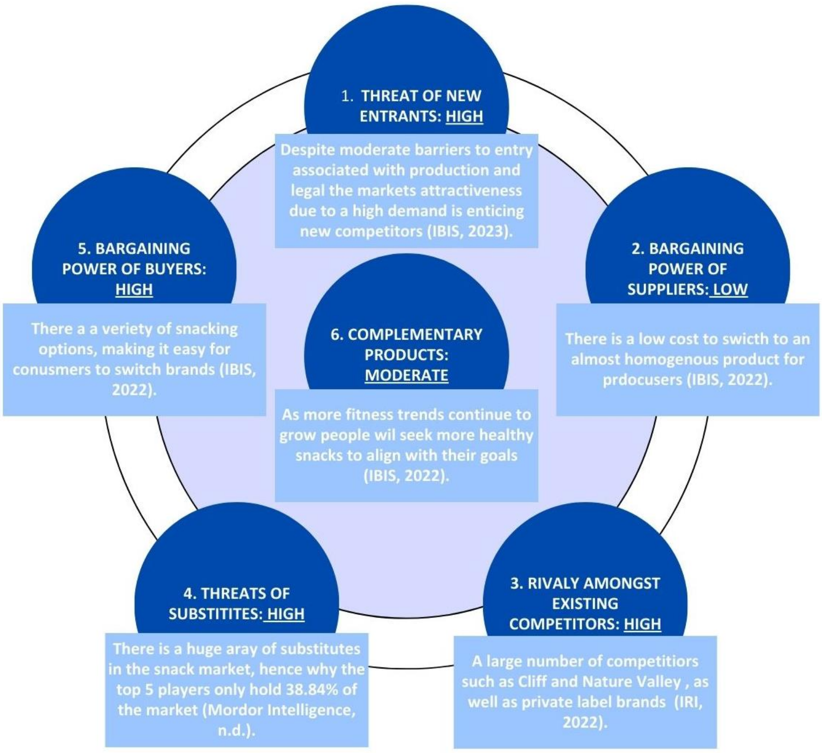

Figure 13

3.4.2. Strategic Group Analysis

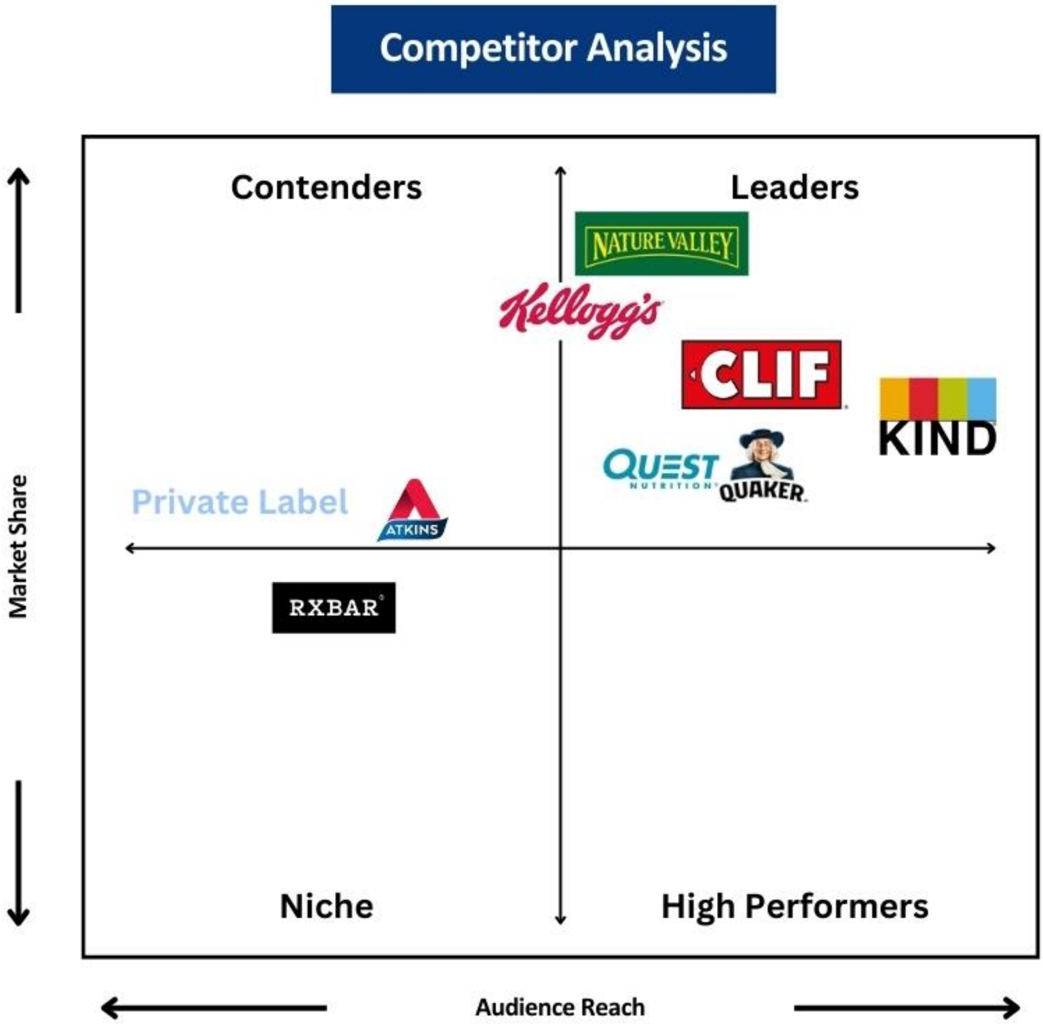

Figure 14: refer to Figure 6 for justification (SOI, 2023)

4. Problem Analysis

This report has identified a concerning misalignment between Kind's actions and brand values, which could jeopardise the company's future. Figure 5, outlined emerging path dependencies that Kind is beginning to overlook, endangering the brands future success. Outlined below are some problems contributing to this misalignment.

4.1. Problem One: Supply Chain Transparency

This report raises concerns about Kind's supply chain transparency. While Kind clearly labels the ingredients in their bars, there is no detailed information on the origin of these ingredients, except for a commitment to source almonds from regenerative agriculture farms by 2030 (Kind, 2022). Moreover, there is a lack of clarity about Kind's manufacturing processes, contrasting sharply with Clif Bars. Clif openly details the sourcing of all ingredients, such as cocoa and kernel oil (Clif, 2021), as well as their innovative manufacturing methods (SF&WB, 2022). Supply chain transparency not being synonymous with competitors in the market raises questions as to why Kind would not want to boast about their 'kind' practices, as they do in other areas of the business.

Since there is no clear reason, nor solution for this problem, this is classified as a wicked problem (Camillus, 2008).

4.2. Problem Two: Product Diversification Choices

This report also identified Kind's product choices as being out of line with their brand values. Kind's mission 'creating a kinder and healthier world- one act, one snack at a time' (Kind, n.d.) is misleading consumers into thinking all of Kinds products are healthy, when actually they are just better than other snack alternatives like crips or chocolate (refer to figure 10). In doing so, Kind's consumers could feel more inclined to indulge in a higher volume of Kind bars, contributing to a much higher calorie intake than an unhealthy snack. Thus, at the moment there is a juxtaposition between the brands intentions of being healthy and tasty, and their actions of producing products like frozen treats. Despite other brands within the snack bar industry diversifying into more unhealthy niches (Parker, 2023), it has more of a negative impact on Kind, whose customer base prides themselves on health and wellness.

Kind's resources will enable them to develop and launch new products that better align with their target market, outlined in section 2. Therefore, their product offering can be rectified, making this a tractable problem (Alford & Head, 2017).

4.3. Problem Three: Increased Competition

The increased competition with the market is leading to increased pressures that are impacting Kind's decision making. Private label snack bars are gaining market share due to higher costs of living, where 46% of US customers now purchase more to save money (Zegler, 2023). Kind is evidently trying to penetrate new sub-markets (refer to figure 4) to combat this competition, but this comes at an opportunity cost of losing their core health conscious customer.

Kind cannot easily influence competition, making this a soft problem (Alford & Head, 2017).

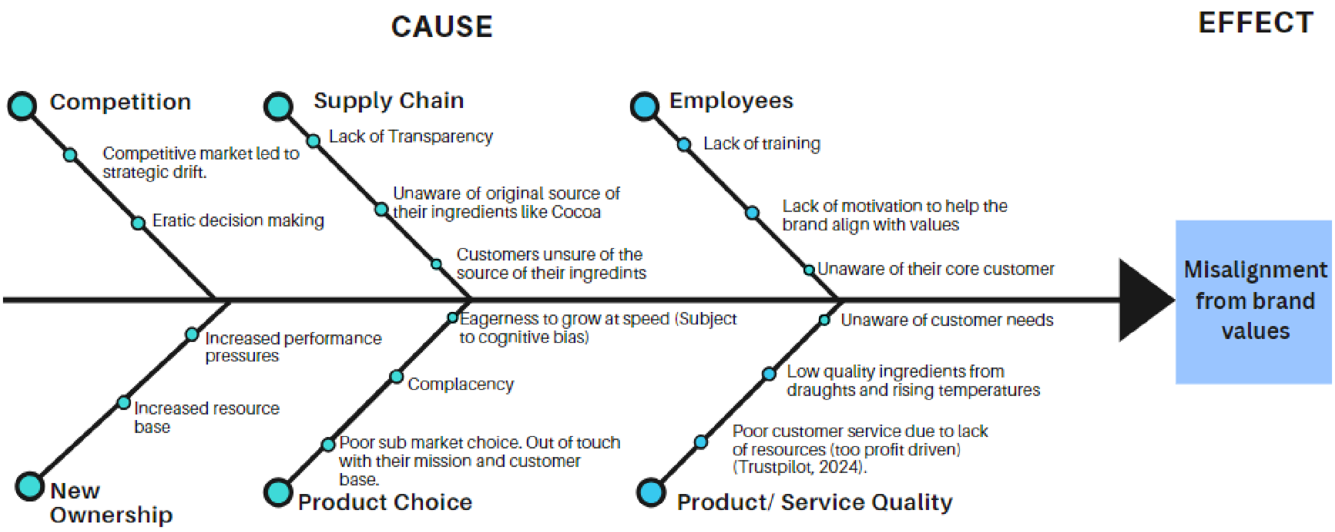

Figure 15: Fishbone Diagram

5. Problem Explanation Utilising Fishbone Diagram

This report appreciates that Figure 15 doesn't reveal Kind's supply chain issues' root cause. CEO Russel Stoke's remarks suggest attempts to cut overheads by enhancing supply chain efficiency, indicating underlying problems (Doering, 2023). Moreover, rising concerns about cocoa market ethics also diminish consumer trust (UCL, 2024).

6. Problem Triage

The triage below will aid Kind's effective resource allocation and priotisation of tasks.

Problem Classification	Problem Area	Score	Problem Type	Urgency
Critical	**Supply chain**	**0.5**	**Wicked**	**Medium<3years**
Critical	**Product**	**0.3**	**Tractable**	**High<2years**
Intermediate	**Competition**	**0.2**	**Soft**	**Medium<3 years**

Figure 16

Kind's lack of supply chain transparency is a complex problem, which requires the greatest application of resources if it is to be resolved. This report believes it will be the most critical problem to solve, requiring Kind to understand the origin of their resources themselves. Although one can make assumptions as to why this facet of their business lacks transparency, there is no clear answer. Moreover, this report does appreciate that it will not have an immediate measurable impact on performance, but as consumers demand more transparency, Kind will be at a competitive disadvantage to their more transparent competition.

Kind's product selection is a relatively urgent issue because of the everchanging competitive landscape that they operate in, substantiating the critical classification. Failing to realign with their health conscious customers could lead to further strategic drift.

Operating in a competitive market, Kind must maintain its innovation while refining its decision making approach. Figure 15 indicates that rising competition could force Kind to make rapid decisions to sustain growth, risking a departure from its core values and brand mission. This report recognises that cultural change will be gradual, prompting its intermediate classification.

7. Direction Setting

In using sections 4, 5 and 6 it is evident that Kind are not on the right track, making unrealistic promises that risk long-term growth, as previously acknowledged by the company itself (Lebetzky, 2015). The utilisation of the 3 C's model will help kind refer back to it's core principles and customers to re-align.

Figure 17: Kind (n.d.-a)

Kind should capitalise on growing market trends in organic, paleo, or gut health niches rather than venturing into other sub-markets (refer to Figure 4). This will enhance their competitiveness in the health and nutritional bar market, which still holds 46.5% market share. Additionally, Kind will benefit from the increased propensity to consume among health-conscious demographics (YouGov, 2024).

8. Options Analysis

Option	Problem	Rationale	Strategic Fit	Appraisal
Diversify Products	2, 3	Despite a decline in the health and nutrition market share (see Figure 7), the number of health conscious consumers is rising. They seek snack bars that meet specific dietary needs like organic or keto. This trend presents an opportunity for Kind to become the preferred brand for healthy snack bars that cater to diverse dietary preferences.	HIGH (Revolutionary change)	Enable Kind to re-align with its brand values. Although it will be costly and require trial and error, it will provide Kind with a huge payoff.
Gain a B Corp certification	1,2 & 3	Increase transparency by verifying brand value claims through a credible third party and ensuring any supply chain or internal issues rectified. Additionally, differentiate from competitors by developing a unique advantage.	HIGH (Revolutionary change)	This aligns perfectly with Kind's brand image and contributes to solving all problems uncovered in this report. However, Kind's size could mean a large restructure is needed for successful certification.
Establish a Run Rub	1,2 &3	Building a brand community can strengthen Kind's commitment to health, offer a competitive edge over rivals without such communities, and provide a platform for testing new products and receiving authentic feedback from health-conscious consumers.	Low (Incremental change)	Although it is a nice addition and will certainly help Kind become more aligned, it will not solve the root causes of the problems outlined.
TikTok Shop	2, 3	Connect with a growing user base and establish real world feedback on products from customers (Cerci, 2023). Also provides an opportunity for Kind to increase their revenue and keep up with their competition.	MEDIUM (Incremental change)	This will be a great addition however it only requires Kind to still fix product issues before it will be successful in the long term.

Figure 18

Example Case

Natura are the largest B Corp company, generating over $5 billion dollars per year (Statista, 2024b) and hold similar values to Kind bars. They now utilise B Corp to illustrate their commitment to both their consumers wellbeing and their wider environment (Aziz, 2022). Thus, highlighting how a larger company than Kind can still certify.

9. Recommendations

This report recommends that Kind bars strive to gain a B Corp certification. Not only does it solve all three core problems outlined in this essay but it also aligns perfectly with Kind's brand image. While the other options are viable, obtaining a B Corp certification will be the largest contributor to sustainable growth of the company. Attaining a B Corp certification will require Kind to provide in depth information regarding their supply chain and internal processes through their impact assessment (B Corp n.d.). Therefore, any existing supply chain issues will have to be rectified prior to the certification attainment. In saying this, critics do argue that large companies such as Nespresso, a B Corp company, still pay it's farmers an income below the poverty line, indicating some slack in the certification process (Raval, 2023).

Despite these claims, the impact assessment will research in depth about Kind's impact on their customers, ensuring their marketing aligns with their product quality (B Corp n.d.) Finally, the B Corp certification will be an asset to Kind's front of package, with more consumers likely to choose healthy food alternatives with certifications (Zegler, 2023). However, it's recent acquisition by Mars' could make it much harder for the brand to obtain a certification due to the lack of agility synonymous with a large company. Kind would also have to justify to consumers as to why they think becoming certified is important, discouraging any claims of the certification being merely a public relations stunt (Akepa, 2021).

Overall, critics of any company's ethical stance will always be present, yet gaining a prestigious certification like B Corp will enable them to support their 'Kind' brand identity and enhance transparency.

10. Implementation

10.1 Key Performance Indicator Table

Although achieving B Corp certification is the ultimate goal, Kind bars must first meet specific internal objectives to qualify with a favourable impact score. Once certified, Kind will incur an annual fee of $62,000 (Darragh, 2022). The cost of obtaining B Corp status largely depends on the ethics of Kind's supply chain.

KPI	Specific	Measurable	Achievable	Relevant	Time Bound
Ingredient Source	Understand where Cocoa, Almonds, Fruits and Honey originate from.	Understand at least 80% of ingredients exact lifecycle.	Yes, even with Cocoa using a similar method to Chocolarder (n.d.).	Addresses transparency concerns.	<3 years
Introduce more health bars	Introduce a organic and Keto friendly bar	At least two new health bars	Yes, with large resource base.	Yes, ensures Kind are not misleading consumers.	<3 years
Company Education	Re-educate employees on brand values and B Corp.	90% of employees complete online training.	Very, utilise online platform	Enables congruence internally towards brand vision.	<2 year
Increase sales	15% increase in sales.	1 Year after becoming certified.	Yes, with increased creditability/ marketing.	Demonstrate B Corp value over competition.	<4 years

Figure 19

10.2 5 Year Plan

Year	Actions
1	**Conduct an extensive audit of the current supply chain, to identify ingredient origin. Implement a roadmap for enhanced transparency.**
	Develop training modules on brand core values and B Corp plan.
	Begin research to improve the nutritional profile of Kind bars.
2	**Develop partnerships with Cocoa farms to ensure ethical practices and improve upon 2030 Almond initiative, making sure climate change impact is limited (Kind, 2023).**
	Launch training programme and roadmap for employee completion
	Reformulate existing products and develop new, healthier options based on the research from Year 1.
3	**Develop marketing campaigns to emphasise their supply chain and product improvements, maintaining transparency as to why they are applying for B Corp.**
	Document all improvements in preparation for application.
4	**Submit application for B Corp certification and achieve it by leveraging documented improvements and impact on its workers, customers, community and environment.**
	Rollout new front of packaging with B Corp certification to boost brand image and regain consumer trust.
5	**Implement marketing and sales strategies to use B Corp status, targeting a 15% sales increase by capitalising on consumer preference for ethical brands.**
	Continue refining supply chain and training practices to uphold B Corp standards and address new sustainability challenges.

Figure 20

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